

Stablecoin Credit Infrastructure for AI Agents

THESIS Businesses are delegating more commercial activity to AI agents and will increasingly fund that activity with credit rather than prefunded balances. A new category of stablecoin-based agentic lenders is being built to finance that spending, alongside the infrastructure needed to underwrite, distribute and manage that credit.

OPPORTUNITY

Businesses are beginning to delegate purchasing and other financial activity to AI agents, moving more digital spend into machine-to-machine workflows. An agent can now pay Exa for a web search or Hyperbolic for GPU inference, making thousands of small purchases a day at only a few cents each. Stablecoins were not built specifically for this use case, but they are already widely used because they can move small payments programmatically and settle them quickly, making them well suited to machine-to-machine transactions.

While payments solve how agents pay, credit expands how much economic activity those payment rails can support. Businesses already use cards and other credit facilities to finance spending. Extending the same model into machine-to-machine commerce would allow agents to transact against approved business credit as spending occurs, with permissions, spending limits, sanctions screening and behavioral checks applied automatically before a payment is approved. As agent activity grows, I believe this creates a new B2B lending market, alongside the underwriting, distribution, identity and risk infrastructure needed to support it.

WHY NOW?

- 01 Machine-to-machine payments are quickly scaling.** x402, launched in May 2025, is an open payment protocol that lets AI agents pay other software automatically for services such as data, API access or compute, without a human checkout or billing process. Monthly payment volume grew 98% MoM to \$1.45M in August 2026 and was up approximately 630x YoY from just ~\$2,300 in August 2025, reflecting rapid adoption.
- 02 Stablecoins are already widely used in machine-to-machine payments.** In Q2 2026, USDC accounted for 99.3% of x402 agent-payment volume, while Circle's Agent Stack had grown to 900+ paid services, showing that stablecoins are already becoming embedded in the infrastructure agents use to transact.
- 03 Credit is entering agent workflows.** t54's Claw Credit and SohoPay both let an agent pay for APIs and compute on credit instead of from a prefunded wallet, with the business settling later. SohoPay, founded by a former American Express executive, is modeling its network on the Amex closed loop and funding payments from a liquidity pool.
- 04 On-chain lending already provides a large capital base.** Outstanding loans across major DeFi lending protocols reached \$26.1B in August 2026, up nearly 30% from June.
- 05 Stablecoins now have a U.S. regulatory framework.** The GENIUS Act, signed in July 2025, established federal rules for payment stablecoins, giving businesses and financial institutions clarity around their use.
- 06 Agent identity and permission standards are forming.** ERC-8004, an Ethereum standard for agent identity and reputation, and Coinbase's Agentic Wallets with programmable spending limits give lenders a way to know which agent is spending and within what bounds.

PROBLEM AND WHITESPACE

- 01 Agent payment infrastructure has developed faster than agent financing.** Businesses can increasingly give agents cards or wallets and allow them to transact autonomously, but the funding layer remains split between traditional credit and prefunded stablecoin balances.
- 02 Corporate cards provide credit and work well for conventional purchases, but are poorly suited to machine-native payments that may occur continuously and for only cents or fractions of a cent.** Stablecoin rails are better suited, but the wallet still must be funded in advance. Neither rail currently combines machine-native payments with embedded credit.
- 03 Existing business credit does not naturally connect to stablecoin payment workflows.** A company can borrow through a card or credit facility, but those funds must still be converted, transferred and made available before an agent can spend them on-chain. Credit therefore needs to be delivered through the same asset and workflow the agent uses to transact.
- 04 On-chain lending provides substantial available capital, but most existing markets are designed around crypto collateral rather than underwriting the operating businesses generating agent expenditure.** The capital exists, but the credit product connecting it to business activity is still underdeveloped.
- 05 Existing on-chain risk and identity tools focus primarily on wallets, transactions and agent behavior.** Business credit requires lenders to connect that activity to the company behind the agent, its repayment capacity and the authority delegated to each agent.

WHERE COMPANIES WILL BUILD

Stablecoin-based agentic credit will create opportunities across direct lending and enabling infrastructure.

Agentic lenders

Stablecoin-native lenders will originate facilities that businesses can make available directly to AI agents, allowing credit to be drawn as expenditure occurs rather than continuously prefunded. Stablecoins support small, frequent transactions while giving lenders access to both institutional and on-chain capital. t54's Claw Credit is an early example, financing API and compute purchases at the transaction level. SohoPay is developing a closed-loop model in which a liquidity pool funds agent payments and merchants pay for acceptance.

I expect agentic lending to expand from transaction-level credit into broader working-capital and receivables financing. As businesses move more agent expenditure onto stablecoin rails, the same infrastructure can support larger credit facilities. The lenders that succeed will need underwriting and governance standards that attract institutional capital without sacrificing the flexibility and liquidity available on-chain.

Embedded credit platforms and marketplaces

Business lending marketplaces already aggregate fragmented credit supply rather than lend from their own balance sheets. Agentic platforms can apply the same model to stablecoin credit. Dedicated marketplaces can compare facilities from agentic lenders, while existing wallets and agent platforms can add credit distribution to an established customer base. This gives businesses one interface for financing instead of requiring separate integrations with each lender.

From conversations with several crypto companies, lending marketplaces with agent-credit features are in development but not yet announced. As stablecoin-native lenders increase, I expect these platforms to become the routing layer for agent credit, with the strongest positions held by companies that combine broad lender access with distribution inside agent workflows.

On-chain credit intelligence

Established fintech lenders and private credit firms will enter stablecoin-based agentic lending, but they will be slower to build the required on-chain underwriting capabilities internally. Legacy systems, compliance constraints, and regulatory uncertainty will create urgency to rely on external providers. This follows an existing pattern, with financial institutions already using firms such as Chainalysis and TRM Labs to interpret on-chain activity.

Existing blockchain analytics firms will naturally extend into credit, and new platforms are being built around on-chain credit intelligence, though focused on wallet and transaction data. Cred Protocol provides on-chain scoring and reporting for AI agents, while Agentic.credit scores autonomous trading agents using verifiable wallet performance and distributes those assessments through APIs and partner integrations. As stablecoin-based agentic lending grows, these providers will become an external risk layer for lenders entering the market.

Identity, permissions and privacy

Institutional activity on public blockchains is already constrained by confidentiality, contributing to the adoption of privacy-enabled networks such as Canton. Agentic lending adds another requirement because lenders must also verify which business controls an agent and what authority has been delegated to it.

Crypto-native providers such as zkMe and Privado ID are developing credentials that prove identity and permissions without publishing the underlying information on-chain. I expect this to become a required layer for institutional agentic lending, with the strongest providers offering credentials that are reusable across lenders while preserving the commercial privacy businesses already expect from traditional finance.

KEY RISKS

- 01 Existing credit is good enough.** Focus on use cases where stablecoins materially improve payment or funding economics.
- 02 Agent spend stays too small.** Target recurring, capital-intensive categories such as compute and infrastructure.
- 03 Agent data adds little to underwriting.** Keep business-level credit analysis at the core.
- 04 Institutional funding is slow.** Build around structures that meet lender risk and compliance requirements.